TOP DATING APPS IN INDIA

And how they strive to keep their users safe

QUACK QUACK

Daily downloads: 16,000

Safety features: Allows users to block profiles, filter out any contact from searches. It also gives safety advice to daters

TINDER

Daily downloads: 15,500

Safety features: Photo verification for all users; faster procedure for reporting sexual violence and harassment; a new feature allows reporting specific images or messages

BUMBLE

Daily downloads: 13,500

Safety features: Provides online trauma support; protects the identity of those reporting harassment; saves messages to prevent the perpetrator from deleting evidence

TRULY MADLY

Daily downloads: 8,680

Safety features: Does not allow users to take screenshots on the app to protect privacy; gives extensive safety advice to users; blocks profiles that are violating user policy

HAPPN

Daily downloads: 8,020

Safety features: Allows reporting and blocking profiles; verifies profiles based on video evidence; certified profiles are given blue seals

*All daily download figures are average estimates for India in Feb. 2022 (Source: apptweak.com)

supportive evidence such as obscene material sent to or posted about the victim. But experts say several other forms of toxic behaviour online can cause mental and emotional harm while the perpetrators escape punishment. "Sometimes, you are being harassed or just receiving emotionally painful messages that might not be 'obscene' but can cause as much pain and injury to your self-esteem and sense of safety," says Dr Sharma.

Experts say small behavioural signs—such as ghosting, breadcrumbing, actively lying or aggression—usually point to larger personality problems. Take ghosting, for example. A Bumble survey found that one in five Indians has been ghosted by someone they had been dating. "Some people avoid addressing emotions or find it easier to move on without having awkward conversations. They are not able to empathise with the receiver's feelings," says Dr Samir Parikh, director of mental health at Fortis Healthcare. Research has also established that ghosting has a clear psychological impact on the receiver—a September 2022 study in the journal *Cyberpsychology* found that those who had experienced ghosting suffered from feelings of exclusion more severely than people who faced other forms of online rejection. "It is an experience like no other—when a person gives you no explanation, no warning and just walks away from you. You feel used, feel useless, feel rejected and depressed about the idea of romance itself," says Karan Sharma (*name changed*), an 18-year-old Delhi student who was recently ghosted by someone he had been speaking to on a dating app for six weeks.

Steps to safe digital dating

Just like when dating someone offline, experts say, staying safe and protecting yourself from emotional and physical harm should be a top priority during digital chats (see *9 Simple Rules for Safe Dating*). It is important that app users communicate with each other about what they seek and are comfortable with in digital dating. Taking time to know your match—their background, interests and personality—is also a must before deciding to meet in person. To stay safe, says Rawal, a user needs to be prudent, use their common sense, be slow in their approach and, most importantly, should be cautious of digital fraudsters or scammers.

Knowing the various safety features your dating app has is also useful. Tinder, for example, has a new procedure to report sexual violence and harassment. Users can report these directly within the app even if they've 'unmatched' from someone. It has also launched photo verification, marked by a blue tick on the profile. Even Bumble has taken user safety seriously (according to the Delhi Police, Shraddha Walkar had met her live-in partner and alleged killer Aaftab Poonawala on Bumble in 2019). "Everyone at Bumble is devastated to hear about this unspeakable crime, and our hearts are with Shraddha's family," says a spokesperson of the US-based firm. "The safety and wellbeing of our members is our top priority, and we have a dedicated global team serving their needs." The app protects the identity of those reporting harassment and saves messages (per its retention policies) so that evidence can't be deleted by 'unmatching'. In 2021, Bumble also partnered with trauma support site Bloom to provide complimentary counselling to users who experience sexual assault or relationship abuse.

While dating apps do bring in convenience, fun and new possibilities, no relationship should be placed above your sense of well-being. "If you find someone is unfaithful, aggressive, manipulative, for example, it is important to communicate how you feel and set clear boundaries," says Athwani. "If they still do not change, you must end the relationship or seek support to do so." That said, even if the relationship goes offline, never socially alienate yourself—so that there is always someone to help you in case it turns sour. ■